

Unit 1: Yoga Asanas in Prone Position

❖ Makarasana(crocodile pose)



is a pose that resembles a crocodile. Makarasana is very beneficial for sciatica, slip disk, stress reduction, and problems affecting the waist and knees. It's also remarkably effective in alleviating respiratory problems and controlling hypertension. Among the large repertoire of asanas in Yoga, Makarasana is an excellent exercise to maintain good mental and physical health. Today's fast paced life and the blind race to achieve more in life, whether at school, college, market or office leaves us stressed, tired and depressed. This has led us trapped with a variety of disorders such

as depression, stress, high blood pressure, cervical spondylitis and waist pain. It is imperative that we take some time out from our everyday life for good health and keep the above problems at bay.

Directions

- Lay a mat and lie down on your stomach in a flat, comfortable and clean ground.
- Raise your shoulder and face slightly and bend your elbows to that you can rest your face on your palms comfortably.
- Ensure that your elbows are not tucked below your chest or resting too far away from the body. Keep your legs straight and joined together.
- Now gradually start exhaling and inhaling. Maintain the posture for at least 30 seconds to 3 minutes. With regular practice you can maintain the posture for 5-10 minutes.

Benefits of Makarasana

- It reduces physical and mental stress.
- Ensures health of the lungs.
- Beneficial in problems such as slip disk and sciatica.
- Provides relief in [asthma](#) and [respiratory problems](#).
- Provides strength and flexibility to the spine.
- Effective in keeping high blood pressure under control.

- Ensure proper working of the small intestine and strengthens the [digestive system](#).

Precautions

- Pregnant women are prohibited from doing this asana.
- People with heart problems and excessive obesity should not perform makarasana
- Ensure that your elbows are comfortable when doing this asana.
- Increase the duration of the exercise gradually according to your comfort.

❖ Bhujangasana (Cobra pose)



Bhujangasana is the Sanskrit name for a popular yoga *asana*, otherwise known as Cobra Pose. It is a gentle backbend, most commonly performed as part of a Sun Salutation, in which it can be used as a less strenuous alternative to *Urdhva Mukha Svanasana* (Upward Facing Dog). The term is derived from two Sanskrit roots; *bhujanga*, meaning "serpent" or "snake" and *asana* meaning "seat" or "posture".

Directions

- First lie prone on the floor with the legs outstretched and feet hip-width distance apart.
- Place the palms down directly below the shoulders, with elbows bent and hugged in towards the torso.
- Pressing the tops of the feet and the pubic bone firmly into the floor, inhale to lift the chest and begin to straighten the arms.
- Keep the shoulders away from the ears, and draw the shoulder blades towards one another to maintain an open chest.
- Only lift as far as possible whilst still keeping the pubic bone connected to the mat, and hold this position for as long as the breath can remain smooth and steady.
- The gaze should be fixed at one point on the floor, in order to maintain a neutral neck position.
- To come out of the pose, exhale to slowly lower back down towards the floor.

Benefits of Bhujangasana

- Strengthens the spine and shoulders
- Tones abdominal muscles
- Opens up the chest and lungs
- Improves flexibility in the upper and middle back
- Enhances blood circulation
- Reduces stress and fatigue
- Aids in respiratory conditions such as asthma

Precaution

- Make sure you perform this *asana* 4-5 hours after having your main meal. This will ensure that you are not uncomfortable lying on your stomach.
- Ensure that you have done some basic warm-up and stretching exercises to loosen your arms, shoulders, neck, and back.
- It is always best to practice [yoga asanas](#) in the morning. However, if you are unable to, make time in the evening.

❖ Shalabhasana (Locust Pose)



In Shalabhasana, ‘*shalabh*’ means ‘locust’ or ‘grasshopper’ and ‘*asana*’ means ‘pose’. The body in the extended torso and stretched hands make this pose look like to locust resting on the field, so the name is locust pose.

The spine gets a smooth stretch in this asana. But to stretch out and lift legs and hands simultaneously, one needs to have good strength in the upper and middle back.

This asana is described under the “Complete illustrated book of the yoga” of Shivanada’s tradition by swami Vishnudevananda in 1960.

Directions

Here are the main steps associated with Salabhasana.

- Lie on the ground on your abdomen and place the hands by the side.
- While breathing out, use the inner thighs to raise your legs slowly and steadily. Make sure that you do not bend your knees. The weight of your body must rest on the abdomen and lower ribs.
- During this phase, you may or may not want to raise your hands with your palms up. Experts often choose to lift their hands up but it is usually difficult for beginners to do so.
- Hold in the final position for about 30 to 60 seconds before releasing the pose.
- Repeat this asana at least thrice.

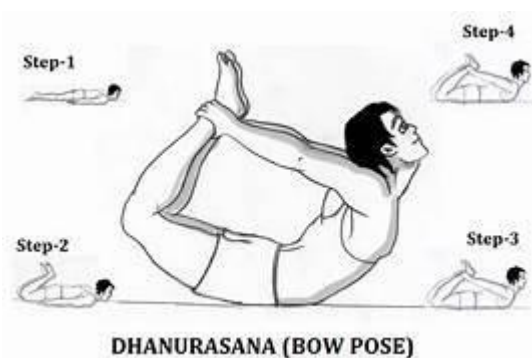
Benefits of Salabhasana

- The asana helps greatly in reducing tension and stress.
- It can energize and refresh fatigued people.
- It generates heat and strength within the body.
- Salabhasana helps to increase agility and flexibility.
- The asana helps to boost mental concentration.
- It helps in clearing the bowels when practiced regularly.
- It helps in resolving knee arthritis and hamstring injuries.

Precautions

- This asana is contraindicated for migraines, headaches, spinal injuries and neck injuries.
- A pregnant or menstruating woman must never practice this asana.
- Do not practice Salabhasana if you have serious back injuries, Spondylolisthesis or knee, and hip injuries.
- The asana should not be performed by those who have high blood pressure or glaucoma.

❖ Dhanurasana(Bow pose)



Dhanurasana is a backbend that deeply opens the chest and the front of the body. The name comes from the Sanskrit *dhanu*, meaning "bow," and *asana*, meaning "pose."

In this asana, the practitioner lies flat on the stomach and bends the knees. Then the arms reach back to grab the ankles. The back arches and the thighs lift off of the floor as the chest pushes forward, bending the body to resemble a bow.

Directions

- Lie down on the floor with your stomach to it. Maintain a width between your two feet and put your arms right beside your body.
- Fold your knees gently and try to hold your ankles.
- Inhale deeply while you lift your chest up along with your legs.
- Pull your legs upwards and back with both your hands.
- Look straight as you look to perform this asana.
- Hold the pose while you try to concentrate on your breathing. Keep your body perfectly taut and steady as a bow.
- Keep on breathing long and deep while you get more comfortable in this pose.
- Stay in this pose for about 15 to 20 seconds
- Finally exhale and get back to starting position.

Benefits of Dhanurasana

- This asana is great when you are looking to strengthen your abdominal muscles and the back.
- Dhanurasana can help in widening and opening up your chest, neck and the shoulders.
- It can effectively stimulate your reproductive organs.
- Your arms and legs muscles can get toned with this asana.
- Dhanurasana adds great flexibility to your back.

- It can work wonderfully to get rid of your stress.
- This asana is perfect for people who are affected by renal disorders.
- Menstrual discomfort can be eased when this asana is practiced regularly.
- The asana can help in losing weight.
- It improves the shape and functioning of the thigh and buttocks muscles.
- It is ideal for men and women suffering from kidney problems.
- The asana can help in cleansing the whole body.

Precautions

- Pregnant women should not practice this asana.
- Do not practice this asana if you are suffering from low or high blood pressure, a hernia, painful sensations around the lower back area, insomnia, headaches, migraines and neck injuries
- It is best to avoid this asana if you recently had abdominal surgery.

Unit 2: Yoga Asanas in Supine Position

❖ Savasana (corpse pose)



Savasana, or *shavasana* is the Sanskrit name for an important restorative *asana*. It is a key component of asana practice in almost every yoga tradition, and is most commonly used at the end of a sequence as a means of relaxation and integration. Some schools also use it to calm the body and mind at the start of a class, and in both Sivananda and Yoga Therapy it is sometimes practiced between postures in order to calm the nervous system.

The term is derived from two Sanskrit roots; *shava*, meaning "corpse", and *asana* meaning "seat" or "posture". The first written record of savasana is found in classic 15th-century

yoga text, *Hatha Yoga Pradipika*, which says: “Lying down on the ground, like a corpse, is called savasana. It removes fatigue and gives rest to the mind”.

Directions

- Lie flat on your back with your legs together but not touching, and your arms close to the body with the palms facing up.
- Keep your eyes gently closed with the facial muscles relaxed and breath deeply and slowly through the nostrils.
- Starting at the top of the head and working your way down to the feet, bring your attention to each part of your body, consciously relaxing it before proceeding on to the next.
- Remain in the shava-asana for between 3 and 5 minutes or longer. If you become sleepy while in the shava-asana begin to breath a bit faster and deeper.

Benefits of Savasana

- This posture brings a deep, meditative state of rest, which may help in the repair of tissues and cells, and in releasing [stress](#). It also gives time for the yoga workout to sink in at a deeper level
- This posture leaves you in a state of rejuvenation. It is the perfect way to end a yoga session, particularly if it has been a fast-paced one.
- It helps reduce blood pressure, anxiety, and insomnia.
- This is an excellent way to ground the body and reduce the Vata dosha (imbalance of the air element) in the body.

Precautions and Modifications

- If lying flat is uncomfortable, place a bolster under your knees to relieve pressure on the lower back.
- Pregnant individuals can practice a side-lying variation.
- Consult a yoga teacher or therapist for personalized modifications.
- For those with difficulty quieting the mind, guided relaxation or soft music can help.

❖ Matsyasana (Fish pose)

Matsyasana is a reclining back-bending asana. The name is derived from the Sanskrit *matsya*, meaning “fish,”



and *asana*, meaning “pose.” *Matsya* is also the name of an incarnation of the god, Vishnu, who manifested himself as a large fish in order to save the earth from a flood. As Matsya, Vishnu was able to carry wise Hindu sages to safety, thus preserving the wisdom of all of mankind.

To enter the pose, the practitioner lies flat on the back then lifts the pelvis so the hands can slide under the buttocks. The back arches and the chest lifts until the crown of the head (or the back of the head for beginners) rests on the floor.

Directions

- Lie on your back with your feet on the floor and knees bent
- Cross your legs in padmasana (lotus pose) and relax the whole body
- Now support your body with elbows, and crossed legs and uplift your chest, engaging your shoulder blades.
- Let the crown of the head touch the floor while maintaining a heart-opening stretch.
- Grip both the big toes with your fingers tightly, keeping your legs extended.
- Lift the thighs and knees off the floor and forcefully press the toes into the ground to deepen the stretch.
- Hold this pose for five to ten slow, deep breaths. Then, slowly release your hold, lift your pelvis slightly, and return to the starting position to complete the process of performing this pose.

Benefits of the Matsyasana (Fish Pose)

- Stretches the chest and neck
- Helps relieve tension in the neck and shoulders
- Provides relief from respiratory disorders by encouraging deep breathing
- Tones the parathyroid, pituitary and pineal glands

Precautions

- People who are suffering from heart diseases, high blood pressure or low blood pressure should not perform Matsyasana.
- Patients of migraine and insomnia should also abstain from practicing the Fish Pose.

- Individuals having serious neck or lower-back injuries are recommended strongly not to perform this pose.
- Men and women who just had an abdominal surgery should not perform Matsyasana. This also applies to people with a hernia.
- If a person has issues like dizziness or cervical spine problems, then he or she should not perform this asana.

❖ Halasana(Plough Pose)



Halasana, also known as the Plough Pose, is a type of asana that mainly falls under Hatha Yoga. The name of the asana is derived from hala or plough since the body actually takes the form of a plough while a person performs this asana. This yoga pose offers a range of physical health benefits and is also ideal for those who want to have greater control over their senses for meditative purposes.

Directions

- Lie on your back with your arms beside you, palms downwards.
- As you inhale, use your abdominal muscles to lift your feet off the floor, raising your legs vertically at a 90-degree angle.
- Continue to breathe normally and supporting your hips and back with your hands, lift them off the ground.
- Allow your legs to sweep in a 180-degree angle over your head till your toes touch the floor. Your back should be perpendicular to the floor. This may be difficult initially, but make an attempt for a few seconds.
- Hold this pose and let your body relax more and more with each steady breath.
- After about a minute (a few seconds for beginners) of resting in this pose, you may gently bring your legs down on exhalation.

Benefits of Halasana

- Halasana strengthens and opens up the neck, shoulders, abs and back muscles.

- Calms the nervous system, reduces [stress](#) and [fatigue](#).
- Halasana also tones the legs and improves leg flexibility.
- Stimulates the thyroid gland and strengthens the immune system.
- Helps women during menopause.

Precautions

- Avoid practicing Plow Pose (Halasana) if you have injured your neck or are suffering from diarrhea and high blood pressure.
- Ladies should avoid practicing Plow Pose (Halasana) during pregnancy and during the first two days of their menstrual cycle.

Naukasana(Boatpose)



Naukasana or Boat Pose is a reclining back-bending yoga posture. Our body is balanced on the sit bones, and the legs are lifted off the floor. The arms are stretched parallel to the ground, and the torso is raised to form a V-shape.

In Sanskrit, 'Nauka' means Boat, and 'Asana' means posture. The final position of Naukasana resembles the shape of a boat. Hence the name Boat Pose.

It is considered a base pose in Hatha Yoga and is practiced commonly. It is similar to the Uttihita Padmasana or Raised Lotus Pose. However, the Naukasana

procedure focuses more on strengthening core muscles than flexibility.

Directions

- Lie on your back with your feet together and arms beside your body.
- Take a deep breath in and as you exhale, lift your chest and feet off the ground, stretching your arms towards your feet.
- Your eyes, fingers and toes should be in a line.
- Feel the tension in your navel area as the abdominal muscles contract.
- Keep breathing deeply and easily while maintaining the pose.

- As you exhale, come back to the ground slowly and relax.
- It also forms a part of the Padma Sadhana sequence, where this yoga pose is practiced after Dhanurasana (Bow Pose).

Benefits

- Naukasana (boat pose) stimulates the muscular, digestive, circulatory, nervous and hormonal systems, tones all the organs and removes lethargy.
- It is extremely useful for strengthening the core, which can improve balance & stability.
- It is helpful in eliminating nervous tension and bringing about deep relaxation.
- It may be performed before shavasana in order to attain a deeper state of relaxation.
- If practised upon waking, it immediately restores freshness.
- It is also useful for women preparing for childbearing and may be practised during the second trimester of pregnancy.

Precautions

- Avoid Naukasana if you have the following conditions:
- Low blood pressure
- Severe [back pain](#) or spinal disorders
- Migraine or chronic headache
- Asthma or heart conditions

❖ Pawanmuktasana (Wind-Relieving Pose)



Pavanamuktasana is a widely practiced reclined pose that helps to release trapped gas from the intestine. It is also known as wind relieving pose or wind liberating pose. The unique thing about this pose is that it can be practiced by both beginners as well as advanced stage yoga students. Practicing Pavanamuktasana can not only help to resolve problems relating to flatulence and constipation but it can also help to get

rid of stubborn deposits of fat in the belly and pelvic area.

Directions

- Lying on your back, inhale both knees into your chest. Wrap the arms around the knees, holding on to opposite elbows, forearms, wrists or fingers.
- Tuck the chin into the chest with the head on the floor. Press the sacrum and tailbone down into the floor as you pull the knees into the chest using the arms.
- Press the shoulders and the back of the neck down into the floor, trying to get the back and whole spine flat to the floor. Relax the legs, feet and hips.
- Breathe and hold for 4-8 breaths, breathing deeply into the belly, actively pressing it against the thighs on the inhalation.
- To release: exhale and release the arms and legs to the floor.

Benefits of the Pawanmuktasana

- Strengthens the back and abdominal muscles
- Tones the leg and arm muscles
- Massages the intestines and other organs in the abdomen
- Helps in digestion and release of gas
- Enhances blood circulation in the hip joints and eases tension in the lower back

Precautions

- Avoid practicing Wind-Relieving Pose (Pawanmuktasana) if you are facing the following health issues: high blood pressure, heart problem, hyperacidity, hernia, slip disc, testicle disorder, menstruation, neck and back problems.
- And after the second trimester of pregnancy.